

states **PUNJAB**

JET-SET JATHEDAR

An entrepreneur who loves the good life, Sukhbir Badal symbolises a generational shift in Punjab politics

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

Sukhbir Singh Badal's official profile lists clay modelling among his favourite hobbies. It is one that has proved extremely useful in the political sense. Having already moulded himself as the crown prince of the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) he is now busy putting the finishing touches to his soaring ambition by taking over the reins of the ruling party from his ageing father, Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal. His meteoric rise in Punjab's power politics makes this three-time MP from Faridkot the man to watch out for and also the man who virtually calls the shots,

with doting father's blessings.

The symbolism of February 1, when the Akali supremo handed over a ceremonial 'siropa' of an exquisitely-crafted sword to Sukhbir before 450 newly-elected delegates at the Golden Temple complex in Amritsar, went way beyond the ritual. By bequeathing his five-decade-old political legacy to his son and heir apparent, the shrewd stalwart has clinched the succession issue once and for all. At 45, the US-educated Sukhbir has become the youngest president of the country's oldest regional party and chief minister-in-waiting. It is also the first time in the party's 87-year-old history that an incumbent president has anointed someone from his immediate

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